

Budget Reflection

By David Daza Salcedo | United Against Drugs NYC

From the time I started thinking about how I would construct the budget for United Against Drugs, it has been abundantly clear that social workers will be an essential part of our agency. I felt from the outset that nothing could work without them because social workers are the ones who interact with our clients and help them in their journey back to health. As I went on building my team, however, there were other considerations that came up, which were not necessarily on my mind at the beginning of the process. I thought, for example, of the need for cleaning staff towards the end of the process. We will be serving vulnerable individuals, so our office will always need to be maintained in good order. I even considered security issues. If we are going to deal with people suffering from addiction, it goes without saying that we need to take care of the safety of both our employees and our clients. There were also sports activities, which I have always envisioned as an important component in helping our clients find healthy outlets for their energy and a sense of purpose.

The balancing of this budget was quite an emotional experience. The moment I asked for \$800,000, I did not have full confidence whether I was doing the right thing since the lowest amount I could ask from the foundation was \$400,000 and the highest was \$1,000,000. That feeling followed me all through the balancing process. When I got to the staff salary portion, and

I discovered it costs nearly \$400,000, I was afraid since I did not know whether there would be enough money for other parts. As a result, for a while, I always selected the cheapest things for my budget such as paper, chairs, and equipment without knowing I was narrowing down the range of options I could choose. After completing the major portions of the budget and checking the total sum, I discovered that there was still enough money left. It was at that moment that I started reconsidering and improving some of the most crucial items that I purchased cheaply such as commercial refrigerators to store the food in the program.

The lack of clarity at the outset was one of the toughest challenges that arose during the process of creating this project. In the first place, it was unclear whether the foundation would accept my request for a grant worth \$800,000. Furthermore, I could not tell in advance the amount of money required to run the organization effectively. Thus, the process itself became a combination of research, decision-making, and doubt. Sometimes, I had to consider the possibility of letting some staff members go or suspending essential services to keep costs low. However, due to the extensive use of web sources, I managed to find affordable prices for high-quality goods needed by the organization. The aspect that left an impression on me the most was the effort to try to understand the feelings and needs of those people who will be our beneficiaries. It is critical to think about how they can feel more comfortable and secure when interacting with us. Overall, this assignment showed me how complicated it must be to manage actual nonprofits with their tight budgets.